

Aokigahara Modern Period Sections

First half of the 20th century, second half of the 20th century, and the 21st century - reproduced from the chat as requested.

A source-led chronology of Aokigahara's modern transformation: from working/scientific/scenic forest, to media death-site, to globalised and managed symbolic field.

Contents

1. First half of the 20th century (1900-1949)
2. Second half of the 20th century (1950-1999)
3. 21st century (2000-2026)

The answer wording is preserved from the chat. Cover, contents, section dividers and typography are newly added for readability.

SECTION 1

First half of the 20th century (1900-1949)

Answer text reproduced below.

First half of the 20th century (1900-1949)

Taking “first half” strictly as 1900–1949, the answer is this:

The first half of the twentieth century is the hinge-period in which Aokigahara is converted from a working/scientific/scenic lava forest into a candidate modern death-site — but it is not yet the fully consolidated post-Nami no Tō “suicide forest”.

That modern identity is not present at the start of the century. In 1900, the forest’s most revealing meanings are cold storage, sericulture, botany, mapping, scenery, and protected nature. By the late 1920s and 1930s, the key change appears: a specific **interwar love-death/media script** begins to attach to Shōjiko/Aokigahara through the Kitagawa Saburō–Kobayashi Yoneko affair. That is the first half-century’s central drama.

1. 1900: Aokigahara as cold infrastructure, not death forest

The most important opening fact is not literary. It is technical.

Around 1900, Hatta Tatsuya brought the cold Fuji wind cave silkworm-egg storage facility under the “Hattatsukan” system. Yamanashi’s prefectural feature says Hatta used the summer-cold Fuji Wind Cave for 蚕種貯蔵 — storing silkworm eggs — so autumn sericulture could become viable, helping stabilise farm households at a time of agricultural difficulty. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is a major inversion. The future “death forest” begins the twentieth century as a **life-timing machine**. The cold cave does not kill; it pauses. Silkworm eggs are held back from hatching until the right season. The lava cave is being used as biological refrigeration.

So in 1900, the forest/cave system means:

cold air;
sericulture;
delayed hatching;
rural stabilisation;
technical adaptation;
Meiji agricultural modernisation.

Not suicide. Not disappearance. Not gothic forest. The first-half-century begins with the lava underworld domesticated as **industrial ecology**.

2. The cave is still threshold-space, but now scientific and economic

This matters psychologically because it reverses the later image.

Later Aokigahara is imagined as a place where a person's life stops. In the wind-cave economy, life does not stop; it is **suspended and scheduled**. The cave is a temporal technology.

That is a deeper finding than it sounds. Aokigahara's caves had already been sacred/water/dragon spaces in older traditions. In the early twentieth century, they are also measurement spaces: temperature, storage, agricultural timing, silk production. The cave is no longer just mythic depth. It is an **instrument**.

That means the twentieth-century death-image did not arise because the forest was useless, abandoned, or socially empty. It arose over the top of a landscape already being used, measured and economically rationalised.

3. 1911: Aokigahara enters international botanical science

The next decisive layer is botanical.

Bunzō Hayata's **1911** English-language monograph, *The Vegetation of Mt. Fuji*, is the key scientific source. The Biodiversity Heritage Library identifies it as a 1911 Maruzen publication with a full plant list and botanical map of Fuji's vegetation.

(biodiversitylibrary.org) Google Books' preview metadata also shows "Aogigahara" among the indexed terms, alongside lava, conifer forest, deciduous forest, altitude bands and Mt Fuji plant distribution. (books.google.com)

This gives us Aokigahara in a completely different register: not as a place of despair, but as a data point in vegetation science.

The important shift is from local familiarity to **scientific legibility**. The forest becomes a zone in a botanical map. It is classified, compared, indexed, and folded into modern natural history.

So by 1911, Aokigahara has at least three modern identities:

local working forest/cave system;
scientific vegetation zone;
scenic Fuji-foot forest.

Still not yet the suicide forest.

4. 1913: the wind cave becomes image-object

A small but revealing source is the 1913 item 八達館富士風穴：蚕種貯蔵風穴ノ入口, a manuscript/watercolour by Sasaki Chūjirō. CiNii identifies it as a 1913 hand-drawn watercolour of the entrance to the Hattatsukan Fuji Wind Cave silkworm-egg storage wind cave. (ci.nii.ac.jp)

This is not a major narrative source, but it matters. It shows the wind cave as something worth picturing. Not a haunted forest mouth, but a technical/cultural object: the entrance to a storage system.

Again, the first-half twentieth-century Aokigahara is not initially a death-stage. It is an object of agriculture, science, documentation, and image-making.

5. The Shōjiko tourist gaze carries over from 1895 into the twentieth century

Although Shōji Hotel begins just before the century, in **1895**, it shapes the early twentieth-century context. MLIT's tourism database says Harry Stewart Whitworth, later naturalised in Japan, opened a European-style hotel overlooking Lake Shōji in 1895, called the area the "Oriental Switzerland", and made it one of the first Fuji Five Lakes destinations popular with foreign visitors. (mlit.go.jp)

Why does this matter for 1900–1949? Because the early twentieth-century Aokigahara/Shōji landscape is already being seen through an outsider scenic frame. Lake, Fuji, Ōmuro-yama, and the forested foreground become view, composition, retreat, photograph, hotel, picturesque object.

This is the second inversion. The later death-image depends on isolation and non-return. But the early twentieth-century tourist image depends on **arrival and viewing**. Outsiders come not to disappear but to look.

6. The forest becomes a view before it becomes a death-script

This is critical.

From Shōji, the forest sits as the dark green middle-ground below Fuji. The "child-holding Fuji" view, with Ōmuro-yama in front of Fuji, is the visual grammar. MLIT's Shōjiko page stresses the "子抱き富士" view and Whitworth's tourist promotion. (mlit.go.jp)

So before Aokigahara becomes a place to enter, it becomes a place to **view**.

That matters because the later death-image will depend on a reversal of perspective:

early twentieth century: look across the forest at Fuji;

later death-discourse: enter the forest and vanish from view.

The eye-line collapses. The scenic foreground becomes the engulfing interior.

7. 1925: 富士山の自然界 gives the prefectural/scenic-natural frame

The major Taishō source is 山梨県編『富士山の自然界』, published in **1925**. NDL's Next Digital Library record gives the table of contents, and it is exactly the source one would

want: after sections on routes, Kawaguchiko and Saiko, it includes 青木原, 大正道, and 剱の海. (lab.ndl.go.jp)

This is an extremely important pre-death-label source. It shows Yamanashi Prefecture itself presenting the forest/lake region as part of Fuji's natural world. The sequence matters:

Kawaguchiko;
Saiko;
Aokihara;
Taishō Road;
Seno-umi.

So in 1925, Aokigahara is in the official descriptive order of **nature, road, lake history and regional geography**.

The key question for the next archival pass would be: does the 1925 text describe Aokihara as difficult, trackless, eerie, scenic, botanical, primeval, or dangerous? The table of contents alone cannot answer that. But it proves that before the 1928 love-death incident, Aokigahara is already named and placed in a prefectural natural-history narrative.

That is the precondition for outsiders to know it.

8. 1925 also preserves the old lake memory

The same table of contents includes 剱の海 / **Seno-umi** immediately after Aokihara and Taishō Road. (lab.ndl.go.jp)

That is crucial. Even before the modern suicide identity is fixed, the official local memory still ties Aokigahara to the lake that disappeared under the 864 lava. The forest is not only a tree-place. It is the afterlife of a water-place.

This matters because the deepest historical structure remains:

lake-world → lava destruction → forest → scenic object → death-script.

In 1925, Yamanashi is still foregrounding the lake-geological memory, not suicide.

9. 1926: the natural-monument frame — but with an important correction

Previous shorthand can mislead here. The present cultural-property name is 富士山原始林及び青木ヶ原樹海, and the Cultural Heritage Online page gives the designation date as **24 February 1926**. (online.bunka.go.jp) But Yamanashi's more detailed cultural-property page clarifies the historical sequence: in 1926, 富士山原始林 was designated, including areas around the Shōjiguchi climbing route, Ōmuro-yama, Yumiizuka, Oniwa/Okuniwa; only in **2010** was a wider Aokigahara Jukai area added and the name changed to include Aokigahara explicitly. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

That correction matters.

The 1926 designation does not mean “the whole modern Aokigahara suicide forest was officially designated as such”. It means Fuji’s primeval/natural forest value was being state-recognised in the interwar period, and the later Aokigahara expansion builds on that older conservation frame.

So the first-half twentieth-century official frame is:

representative primeval forest;
rare forest flora;
natural monument;
scientific/natural value;
protected landscape.

Again, not death-site.

10. The “primeval forest” label is already a modern construction

The 1926 natural-monument language matters because it creates an official “primitive/primeval forest” aura. Cultural Heritage Online’s explanation cites Hayata’s 1911 *The Vegetation of Mt. Fuji* and describes different forest zones around Fuji, emphasising primeval scenery and altitudinal vegetation belts. (online.bunka.go.jp)

This is where the modern myth can later take root. “Primeval” is not suicide. But it is a powerful label. It makes the forest feel outside ordinary time, even though Aokigahara itself is geologically young by forest standards.

So by the mid-1920s, the forest/Fuji-foot world has been given a modern sublime vocabulary:

primitive;
rare;
natural;
protected;
scientific;
scenic;
ancient-looking.

The later death-image will not replace this entirely. It will parasitise it.

11. 1928: the central rupture — Kitagawa Saburō and Kobayashi Yoneko

The key first-half-twentieth-century death layer is the **1928 Shōjiko/Aokigahara double-suicide affair**, involving Tokyo Higher School professor **Kitagawa Saburō** and **Kobayashi Yoneko**.

The strongest fully reliable open citation is not the original newspaper itself, but an NDL reference case. It identifies Inagaki Masami's 1981 book 『その前夜、樹海に死す』 as a work dealing with the Aokigahara double-suicide affair of Kitagawa and Kobayashi. The same NDL case confirms that Kitagawa's letters were published as 「純愛の手紙」 in 婦人公論 21(5), May 1936, pp.242–255. (crd.ndl.go.jp)

This is the real hinge.

Why? Because it shows the affair was not just a local death. It became material for later print culture. Private correspondence was repackaged as magazine sentiment. A personal death became a reproducible emotional script.

12. What 1928 changes

Before 1928, the dominant accessible layers are:

cold cave;
sericulture;
botany;
tourism;
natural scenery;
state natural-monument thinking.

After 1928, a new layer appears:

modern romantic/intellectual death;
urban person travels to Fuji-lake/forest zone;
the place becomes emotionally legible as final destination;
the event can be retold, sentimentalised, printed, filmed, sung, or folded into later memory.

This is not yet the fully modern “suicide forest” reputation. But it is likely the first modern **death-romance attachment** strong enough to matter.

13. Be careful: the 1928 layer is still partly archive-dependent

A blog recollection of the 青葉の夢・精進湖心中事件 gives more detail: Kitagawa was a 31-year-old Tokyo Higher School science professor; Kobayashi was a 22-year-old café worker; the incident occurred in Shōwa 3 / 1928; the later title 青葉の夢 belonged to a film, while the actual incident was known as 精進湖心中. (tama5ya.net)

This is useful, but lower-trust than NDL. It should not be treated as the final historical basis. The key archival targets remain original 1928 newspapers, Yamanashi local papers, later Asahi references, 婦人公論, and Inagaki's book.

The safe position is:

1928 is very likely the first major modern death hinge, but its exact media mechanics still need archive locking.

That is not caution for its own sake. It matters because the whole argument depends on not pretending that later folklore is primary evidence.

14. The psychological form of the 1928 event is not “suicide forest” yet — it is shinjū/death-romance

The 1928 affair should not be flattened into modern “suicide forest” discourse.

Its likely register is closer to:

心中 — double suicide / love-death;
純愛 — pure love;
scandal;
class/intellectual mismatch;
modern urban romance;
newspaper sensation;
private letters becoming public affect.

This is different from the later Takahashi-type “quiet self-disappearance” Aokigahara profile. The 1928 layer is social and melodramatic. It is not yet anonymous self-erasure. It is still a story with names, letters, lovers, social difference, and press narrativisation.

That distinction matters. The forest does not become “the place for faceless disappearance” in one jump. First it becomes a **stage for a named romantic death story**.

15. 1930: mapping and military/state legibility

NDL records a 1930 富士山近傍図：五万分一, edited/published by the Army Land Survey Department / 陸地測量部. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

This is not a death source, but it belongs in the first-half-century story. The forest region is being mapped at state/military cartographic scale. The modern state can place roads, lakes, slopes, settlements and forest in a measurable grid.

Again, this cuts against myth. The place later imagined as unfindable is also being made legible by maps.

This creates one of Aokigahara’s long contradictions:

myth says: once inside, you cannot orient;
state cartography says: the region is measurable, printable, gridded, owned by maps.

That contradiction only intensifies later with aerial photography, lidar, GPS and drones.

16. 1936: “Pure Love Letters” — the most revealing interwar emotional source

The **1936 *Fujin Kōron*** item is probably the single most revealing first-half-twentieth-century source.

NDL confirms the exact article:

北川三郎「純愛の手紙」『婦人公論』21(5), 1936.5, pp.242–255. (crd.ndl.go.jp)

That title — “Pure Love Letters” — is the key. The affair is not being packaged as “mental illness”, “suicide prevention”, “forest danger”, or “police case”. It is packaged as sentimental literature for magazine readership.

This is the exact mechanism by which a death-event becomes cultural material.

Private crisis becomes public emotion.

Public emotion becomes repeatable story.

Repeatable story attaches to place.

Place becomes available as destination.

That is the birth of the modern death-script.

17. Why women’s-magazine publication matters

Fujin Kōron was not a police gazette. It was a major women’s magazine. The publication of the letters there means the affair entered the sphere of middle-class reading, sentiment, romance, moral anxiety, and modern gender discourse.

This matters because Aokigahara’s later reputation is not born merely from geography. It is born from **reading**.

The forest becomes charged because people encounter it through stories: newspaper items, letters, films, songs, novels, guide talk, and later TV/internet. In 1936, the Kitagawa/Yoneko material is already being processed as emotional text.

That is the crucial first-half transformation: the place becomes narratable as final scene.

18. “青葉の夢”: film/song afterlife — important but lower-trust until verified

The blog source says 青葉の夢 was the film title connected with the Shōjiko affair, and that the incident itself was remembered as 精進湖心中. (tama5ya.net)

This is important because it suggests the death event moved beyond newspapers and magazines into film/popular song. But I would still mark it as **not fully locked** from open evidence here. It needs direct verification through film databases, period newspapers, record catalogues, and NDL holdings.

If verified, it would matter enormously. It would mean Aokigahara/Shōjiko's death identity was circulating through early Shōwa popular culture before Matsumoto.

But for now the correct evidential status is:

high-value lead; not final proof.

19. The possible “魔の樹海” layer

A recent Japanese research project, 青木ヶ原樹海史伝, claims that the 1928 Shōjiko incident, later deaths, and newspaper/magazine culture produced an early “魔の樹海” image before Matsumoto. Its Note magazine describes itself as source-based historical research into Aokigahara and includes articles on boundaries, myths, maps, old routes and other historical traces. (note.com)

This is valuable as a lead, but not a replacement for archival verification. The exact phrase 魔の樹海 needs confirmation in original newspaper databases: Asahi, Yomiuri, Mainichi, Yamanashi Nichinichi, and NDL microfilm.

If 魔の樹海 is found in the 1930s, that is decisive: Matsumoto did not create the dark label. He inherited and literary-concentrated an existing one.

But I would not yet write that as locked fact. I would write:

probable interwar dark-label formation; archival confirmation pending.

20. 1930s: the modern death identity is still not the whole forest

Even if the 1928/1936 layer is strong, the forest's first-half-century identity remains multiple. It is simultaneously:

wind-cave infrastructure;
botanical object;
scenic foreground;
map object;
protected/primitive forest;
Shōjiko tourist landscape;
interwar death-romance site.

That multiplicity is the point. The death-image does not arrive on an empty surface. It competes with and contaminates existing identities.

This explains why Aokigahara is so powerful later. It is not a mere “bad place”. It is a beautiful, protected, scientifically interesting, locally used, scenic Fuji landscape that becomes overlaid by death-narrative.

The conflict between “living forest” and “death forest” begins here.

21. 1940–1945: the war years are a source gap, not an interpretive playground

For 1940–45, I do not have strong open evidence tying Aokigahara specifically to a new death-site development. The obvious risk would be to invent a wartime psychological story — militarism, death ideology, national sacrifice, and so on — and paste it onto the forest.

I would not do that.

The honest position is:

the war years are an evidential gap in the open source base I have used here.

That does not mean nothing happened. It means the source trail needs local newspapers, police records, wartime maps, Yamanashi administrative archives, local histories of Saiko/Shōji/Narusawa/Kamikuishiki, and postwar recollections.

For now, the 1900–1949 story remains dominated by the 1900–1936 sequence.

22. 1945–1949: immediate postwar silence, but the terrain is ready for the next transformation

Again, I find no strong open source in this pass that proves a major Aokigahara suicide-discourse escalation in 1945–49.

But structurally, by 1949 the ingredients are already assembled:

a forest known as difficult and primitive-looking;
Shōjiko/Saiko/Fuji scenic tourism;
cartographic accessibility;
cave/tourism/road infrastructure;
the 1928 death-romance memory;
1936 magazine re-publication of the letters;
possible film/song afterlife;
possible prewar “魔の樹海” labelling.

So the postwar period inherits a prepared symbolic field. The later 1959–60 Matsumoto moment does not appear from nowhere. It lands on ground already named, mapped, scenicised, and partially death-coded.

23. The decisive first-half-century sequence

Compressed:

1900: Fuji Wind Cave under Hattatsukan; cave as sericultural cold storage.

(pref.yamanashi.jp)

1911: Hayata's The Vegetation of Mt. Fuji; Aokigahara as botanical/scientific zone.

(biodiversitylibrary.org)

1913: Sasaki's hand-drawn/watercolour image of Hattatsukan Fuji Wind Cave entrance. (ci.nii.ac.jp)

1925: Yamanashi's Fuji-san no shizenkai includes Aokihara, Taishō Road, and Seno-umi in official natural-geographical framing. (lab.ndl.go.jp)

1926: Fuji primeval forest receives natural-monument recognition; Aokigahara as wider explicit addition comes later, but the conservation/primitive-forest frame is established. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

1928: Kitagawa/Kobayashi Shōjiko/Aokigahara double-suicide affair — central modern death hinge, archive-dependent in detail but strongly supported as later subject of Inagaki and NDL reference trail. (crd.ndl.go.jp)

1930: Fuji-area map by Army Land Survey Department; state cartographic legibility. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

1936: Kitagawa's letters published as "Pure Love Letters" in Fujin Kōron; private death becomes magazine sentiment. (crd.ndl.go.jp)

1940s: currently a weak open-source zone; do not overclaim without archive work.

24. What this period is not

It is not ancient suicide tradition.

It is not yet post-Nami no Tō Aokigahara.

It is not yet the post-1970s media feedback loop.

It is not yet the clinical "self-disappearance / quiet death" site described in Takahashi's 1980s study. That later clinical finding is useful as a comparison, but it belongs outside this first-half period. (cir.nii.ac.jp)

The first half of the twentieth century gives the **pre-clinical, pre-Matsumoto, interwar formation layer**.

25. The deepest psychological meaning of 1900–1949

The deepest psychological shift is this:

Aokigahara moves from a place that manages life to a place that can stage death.

At the start of the century, the cave suspends silkworm life so farmers can survive. By the 1930s, the forest/lake zone is capable of holding a modern "pure love" death narrative. That is the real transformation.

Not:

"forest was always deathly."

But:

a living/working/scientific/scenic forest acquires a modern emotional wound.

The 1928 affair matters because it makes the place available for a particular kind of modern Japanese story: educated man, café woman, forbidden/intense attachment, disappearance from Tokyo, Fuji-lake death, letters, magazine publication, possible film/song memory. That is not timeless folklore. It is modernity.

26. Final thesis: first half of the twentieth century only

From **1900 to 1949**, Aokigahara is not yet the fully formed suicide forest. It is a contested modern landscape.

In 1900, its caves belong to sericulture and cold storage. In 1911, its vegetation belongs to botany. In 1925, it belongs to Yamanashi's natural-history and scenic geography. In 1926, the wider Fuji primeval-forest frame enters national conservation. In 1928, the Kitagawa/Kobayashi affair appears to attach a modern death-romance to Shōjiko/Aokigahara. In 1936, the publication of Kitagawa's "Pure Love Letters" in *Fujin Kōron* proves that the affair had become reproducible emotional culture. By 1949, the forest is not yet Matsumoto's forest, but it is ready for Matsumoto: named, mapped, scenicised, naturalised, and already touched by interwar death-sentiment.

The exact formulation is:

The first half of the twentieth century is the period in which Aokigahara's older identities — cold cave, working forest, scientific vegetation zone, scenic Fuji foreground, natural monument landscape — are first contaminated by modern media death-romance. The suicide forest is not born fully formed here, but the first modern script is written here: not anonymous self-erasure yet, but named, literate, sentimental death at the forest-lake edge.

The next stage, **1950–1959**, should be treated separately, because that is the immediate bridge into Matsumoto rather than the first half proper.

SECTION 2

Second half of the 20th century (1950-1999)

Answer text reproduced below.

Second half of the 20th century (1950-1999)

Second half of the twentieth century — **1950–1999** — is the decisive modern transformation.

The answer is not “Matsumoto alone did it.” That is too simple. The real sequence is:

postwar scenic/tourist forest → 1959–60 literary vanishing-scene → 1960 film image → 1966 local disaster and village displacement → 1970s search/media ritual → 1974/1978 press hardening → 1980s police/clinical discovery of the self-erasure profile → 1990s manual/subculture/late-Heisei suicide crisis → 1999 threshold into the internet/globalised Aokigahara.

That is the half-century in one line.

1. 1950–1958: the quiet bridge before Matsumoto

The 1950s before Nami no Tō are currently the weakest open-source zone. That matters. It would be intellectually dishonest to invent a fully documented 1950s Aokigahara suicide culture without archive work in Yamanashi local newspapers, police records, tourism guides, youth-hostel material and postwar maps.

What can be said is narrower but important. By the 1950s, Aokigahara already has the necessary preconditions: postwar tourist access around Saiko/Shōjiko, cave tourism, youth-hostel culture, road/rail approach from Tokyo, a prewar death-romance residue from the 1928 Kitagawa/Kobayashi affair, and official/scenic/natural framing from the first half of the century. The forest is available, named, scenic and reachable. But it is not yet the nationally overcoded “suicide forest” of later decades.

So the 1950s bridge is not empty. It is a **prepared surface**.

2. 1959–1960: Nami no Tō supplies the portable modern image

The central literary event is Matsumoto Seichō’s Nami no Tō. Bibliographic sources differ slightly on the exact magazine run, but the useful range is **1959–1960**. One Matsumoto bibliography gives publication in Josei Jishin from May 1959 to July 1959, while another Matsumoto research document lists Nami no Tō in Josei Jishin from May 1959 to June 1960; the point for our purpose is that the work belongs exactly to the 1959–60 transition. (seityoudasoku.garyoutensei.com)

The Japan Travel Bureau tourism-resource page says the novel was published in 1960 and directly quotes/summarises its Aokigahara passage: trees driving roots into cracks in scattered lava, white dead standing trunks, fallen trees like snakes, ancient moss, “untrodden primitive forest”, and the idea that if one gets lost there, even the body cannot

be found. It says the heroine's disappearance into the forest fixed a dark image of Aokigahara. (tabi.jtb.or.jp)

This is the key: Matsumoto does not merely mention the forest. He compresses its physical affordance into a literary mechanism.

The forest becomes:

lava-rooted;
white-dead;
snake-fallen;
moss-ancient;
pathless;
body-swallowing;
feminised through Yoriko's disappearance;
morally ambiguous rather than graphically violent.

The effect is not "instruction". It is **image-concentration**. Matsumoto makes the forest portable as a final scene.

3. The Matsumoto scene works because it is not loud

This is the literary precision people miss.

The final image does not function like horror. It functions like erasure. It does not need a visible body, violent spectacle, or explicit mechanics. The woman is absorbed into scenery. That is why it later fits Aokigahara so well.

A bridge says: public event.

A railway says: rupture and impact.

A building says: spectacle and fall.

Aokigahara says: subtraction, unreadability, non-recovery.

Matsumoto's genius, whether intentional or not, was to make the forest's geology and ecology serve a social-emotional fantasy: the person leaves the human order and becomes unlocatable.

4. 1960: the film makes the vanishing image visual

The 1960 Shochiku film adaptation matters because it turns the literary image into cinema. Shochiku's official page says the film was distributed in 1960 and ends with Yoriko heading to Fuji's foot; her figure is gradually “吸いこまれていった” — absorbed or sucked into the black sea of trees. (shochiku.co.jp)

That wording is crucial. It is not just “she went into the forest”. The film synopsis itself describes absorption.

So by 1960, Aokigahara has been made into:

a page-image;
a film-image;
a romantic/tragic female vanishing-image;
a national popular-culture image.

The forest is no longer merely a local place. It has entered mass reproducibility.

5. But 1960 is not enough by itself

The standard claim — Nami no Tō caused the suicide-forest reputation — is too crude.

The better reading is: Nami no Tō supplied a **template**, but the template became socially dangerous only when later press, searches, bodies, police, locals and readers repeatedly reattached it to real cases.

A 2026 Japanese source project argues that the statistical peak was not immediately after 1960 but much later, especially in the late 1970s, and that the 1928 Shōjiko double-suicide and media chains matter as earlier layers. I would treat this source as a strong interpretive lead rather than final proof, but its main warning is right: do not let Matsumoto become a magic monocause. ([note.com](#))

So:

1960 gives the script.

The 1970s make the script operational.

6. 1966: the Saiko/Neba disaster tears the human landscape

The next essential event is not suicide. It is local disaster.

On **25 September 1966**, typhoon-related heavy rain caused debris flows around old Ashiwada village, striking the Neba and Saiko districts. The NDL reference case records 94 dead or missing and major house destruction. ([crd.ndl.go.jp](#)) MLIT's Fuji Sabo material gives the micro-detail: heavy rainfall loosened mountain slopes; debris flows struck Neba and Saiko; Neba lost 63 of 235 people, Saiko lost 31 of 513; search and rescue were extremely difficult and Self-Defense Force searches continued until 7 October with more than 16,000 personnel mobilised. ([cbr.mlit.go.jp](#))

The official Iyashi-no-Sato Neba history says 37 of 41 thatched houses were destroyed or half-destroyed, and that the settlement's peaceful life was "taken in an instant"; the recreated thatched village opened in 2006. ([saiko iyashi no sato neba](#))

This belongs in the Aokigahara story because it changes the Saiko/Neba human landscape behind the Matsumoto geography. The old village world around the forest edge is ruptured. What had been a living local landscape becomes disaster memory, relocation, reconstruction, and later heritage-tourism.

This is a second kind of disappearance: not individual self-erasure, but village erasure.

7. 1966 also creates a competing death-memory

This matters deeply.

Aokigahara's post-1960 reputation is usually read through suicide. But in the Saiko/Neba locality, 1966 creates a different death archive: landslide, mud, destroyed houses, missing relatives, mass search, forced relocation.

So the forest/lake region after 1966 carries at least two death systems:

the external/media system: Aokigahara as suicide forest;

the local/disaster system: Neba/Saiko as lost village and collective trauma.

This is why local meanings cannot be reduced to the outsider death-label. The local population has its own catastrophe. Aokigahara's "suicide forest" reputation overlays a neighbouring history of disaster and displacement.

8. 1970: the search ritual begins

A 2009 China.org/People's Daily Japanese-language report says annual autumn searches involving police, volunteers and media had been conducted for over 30 years and began in **1970**; it says early searches found around 20 bodies, later increasing, with 57 in 1994, over 70 in 1999, and 78 in 2002. This is a secondary source and not ideal, but it is useful because it gives the search ritual chronology. (japanese.china.org.cn)

The important thing is not only the numbers. It is the ritual form.

Once annual searches begin, the forest stops being only a literary site. It becomes a recurring public operation:

police;
volunteers;
media;
forest sweep;
body count;
news coverage;
renewed reputation.

This is where the reputation becomes institutionalised.

9. Search is not neutral: it manufactures visibility around disappearance

The paradox is central.

People may go to Aokigahara to become unfindable. The annual search turns that unfindability into spectacle and administration. The bodies, where found, become numbers, articles, rumours, operational knowledge and renewed public imagination.

So the 1970 search ritual converts the forest from “place of disappearance” into **place where disappearance is periodically audited**.

That is a modern transformation. The forest now has a calendar.

10. 1974: the press explicitly ties a death to Nami no Tō

Diamond Online, excerpting a gatekeeper/prevention book, cites a **25 April 1974 Mainichi Shimbun** article with the headline: “『波の塔』まくらに樹海で若い女性が自殺” — a young woman dies in the forest with Nami no Tō as a “pillow”. (diamond.jp)

That is one of the most important media nodes in the whole second half.

Why? Because it does the reattachment work:

real death + book object + forest + headline.

The novel is no longer just the source of an image. It becomes an object found beside, or symbolically attached to, the death. The press turns the scene into a feedback loop: the book describes the forest; the body with the book confirms the forest; the article tells the public the confirmation.

This is how media contagion works without needing crude direct causation.

11. 1978: “魔の樹海に泣く地元” and the local burden becomes public

Diamond Online also cites a **5 June 1978 Asahi Shimbun** article titled “月曜ルポ 魔の樹海に泣く地元”, which said that since Matsumoto’s Nami no Tō appeared in 1960, suicides had increased in Aokigahara. (diamond.jp)

This is probably the decisive press hardening.

The title itself matters: “**the local area weeps over the demon/magic forest.**”

By 1978 the story has at least four layers:

Matsumoto’s literary forest;
real repeated deaths;
media label “魔の樹海”;
local suffering under the label.

So the late 1970s are when Aokigahara becomes not merely famous but reputationally trapped. The label now injures the local area.

12. The 1970s are more important than 1960

If I had to choose the most important decade in the modern story, it is the 1970s, not the 1960s.

1960 supplies the mythic image.
1966 fractures the local landscape.
1970 begins repeated searches.
1974 ties a body directly to the novel in newspaper form.
1978 publicly names the local burden and attaches the “魔の樹海” image.

That is the decade of consolidation.

By 1979, Aokigahara is not merely a forest in a famous novel. It is a known social problem, a media site, a police/search site, and a reputational wound.

13. 1982–1984: the police data gives the deepest clinical truth

Yoshitomo Takahashi's 1986 preliminary study is the strongest hard evidence in the whole second-half period. It examined **116 suicide attempts** in Aokigahara over **1982–1984**, using Fuji Yoshida Police Station material. The abstract says Aokigahara was already famous as a high-frequency suicide area, but detailed reporting had not previously existed.

(cir.nii.ac.jp)

The findings are crucial:

actual protected attempts were extremely low compared with the number estimated from completed suicides;

the male:female ratio among attempters was **2.9:1**, reversing the usual pattern for attempts;

subjects showed little expression of hostility towards others and tended to wish for **self-disappearance or quiet death**;

crisis intervention was almost entirely police-led, returning people to family in a short time, with almost no psychiatric intervention. (cir.nii.ac.jp)

That phrase — 自己の消滅や静かな死 — is the psychological key to Aokigahara.

14. The 1986 paper proves the forest is not mainly theatrical

This is the most important interpretive point.

Aokigahara's clinical profile, as described by Takahashi, is not primarily “I will show them”, “I hate them”, “I will make a scene”, or “I will accuse the world.” It is quiet self-erasure.

That perfectly explains why Aokigahara differs from other sites. The point is not just death. The point is:

not being seen;

not causing a public scene;

not returning;

not having to speak;

not making the body socially immediate;
becoming absorbed by the landscape.

Matsumoto gave the literary image. Takahashi gives the clinical verification of the wish-form.

15. The 1980s expose a failed intervention model

Takahashi's final finding is administratively brutal: crisis intervention was largely policed, short, family-return oriented, and nearly devoid of psychiatric intervention.
(cir.nii.ac.jp)

That means that by the early 1980s, the forest is already a high-risk site, but the institutional response is underdeveloped. People are intercepted, then rapidly returned. The forest is treated as a policing and family-return problem before it becomes a coordinated mental-health/prevention system.

This is the institutional underside of the suicide forest. The place has outpaced the care system.

16. 1980s: the forest becomes clinically knowable

The 1986 article is also the moment Aokigahara becomes a medical-social object. It is no longer only literature, press, local complaint, or police practice. It becomes data.

This is another transformation:

1959–60: literary image.

1970s: media/search image.

1980s: police-clinical data image.

Each stage makes the forest legible in a different language.

The tragedy is that the underlying wish remains the same: quiet disappearance.

17. 1993: Complete Suicide Manual and the dangerous subcultural turn

The 1990s add a different media object: Tsurumi Wataru's 完全自殺マニュアル, published by Ohta in 1993. Ohta's own 1993 archive lists Kanzen Jisatsu Manual by Tsurumi.
(ohtabooks.com)

I am not going to summarise or reproduce its contents. What matters historically is that, in the 1990s, suicide discourse shifts from tragic newspaper/literary aura into manualised subculture, provocation, youth media, and controversy.

This is a different register from Nami no Tō.

Matsumoto gives tragic disappearance.

Tsurumi belongs to alienated late-Heisei social discourse, anti-moralising provocation, and explicit suicide-information culture.

Aokigahara is transformed by this ecosystem because the forest is now circulating not only as romance or tragedy, but as a known destination within a wider media ecology of “exit”.

18. 1994: the meta-manual and social debate

NDL records [ぼくたちの「完全自殺マニュアル」](#), edited by Tsurumi and published by Ohta in April 1994. ([ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp](#)) Ohta’s 1994 archive also lists the book. ([ohtabooks.com](#))

This is not just another book. It shows that the 1993 manual produced a public discourse around itself. There is now not only a manual but a debate-object: “our Complete Suicide Manual”.

So in the 1990s, the Aokigahara problem belongs to a larger Japanese argument about suffering, autonomy, social pressure, youth, publishing, moral responsibility, and the limits of speech.

Again, I am avoiding the technical content. The important historical point is the **genre shift**: from literary death to informational controversy.

19. 1994–1999: the counts rise into late-Heisei crisis language

The China.org/People’s Daily report says the annual search found 57 bodies in **1994** and more than 70 in **1999**, after early years around 20. ([japanese.china.org.cn](#)) This is a secondary international media source, so I would not use it as final statistical authority without Yamanashi/police records, but it fits the broader late-1990s pattern: Japan’s suicide problem becomes nationally acute around the post-bubble period, with more than 30,000 suicides annually from 1998 onward, as the same report notes for Japan as a whole. ([japanese.china.org.cn](#))

For Aokigahara, the 1990s are when the reputation is no longer merely post-Matsumoto. It is part of a broader late-Heisei social crisis:

economic stagnation;
post-bubble employment insecurity;
debt and shame;
alienated youth and subculture;
manualised suicide discourse;
search operations;
rising public body-count consciousness.

The forest becomes a national social symptom, not merely a literary site.

20. The 1990s also create the pre-internet exploration ecology

A blog account by a later Aokigahara explorer records testimony from someone exploring the forest since the early Heisei period, before the internet became widespread. The account says that at that time there were few books and little information, partly because locals avoided spreading the “suicide famous-place” reputation. It then frames the later internet/blog era as a major change in exploration culture. (ameblo.jp)

This is lower-trust than clinical or official sources, but it is valuable as subcultural memory. It suggests that before the internet, Aokigahara’s field knowledge was scarce, local, rumour-based and partly suppressed. The 1990s sit at the threshold between newspaper/book Aokigahara and web/forum Aokigahara.

So 1999 is not only the end of the century. It is the edge of a new media regime.

21. Environmental degradation and dumping also matter

The second half of the twentieth century is not only suicide. Aokigahara also becomes a site of littering, dumping and environmental-management concern. A later environmental/clean-up history says serious clean-up activity began around **1999–2000**, responding to illegal dumping and rubbish in the forest. (ip-take.com)

This is weaker as a historical source than I’d like, but the theme matters. The forest is being damaged not only symbolically by the death label but materially by rubbish and human misuse.

So by the end of the century Aokigahara has three reputational burdens:

suicide;
dark tourism/exploration;
illegal dumping/environmental degradation.

The “death forest” image is only one part of a broader crisis of use.

22. The second half creates four Aokigaharas

By 1999, there are at least four distinct Aokigaharas.

First, **Matsumoto’s Aokigahara**: the tragic literary forest where Yoriko disappears.

Second, **the media-search Aokigahara**: annual body searches, newspaper headlines, local burden, “魔の樹海”.

Third, **Takahashi’s clinical Aokigahara**: a site of quiet self-disappearance, male-heavy attempts, weak psychiatric intervention and police-led crisis handling.

Fourth, **the 1990s subcultural Aokigahara**: manual controversy, exploration, pre-internet rumour, late-Heisei suicide crisis, the soon-to-arrive web folklore layer.

Those four are not identical. The mistake is to collapse them into one “suicide forest”.

23. What the second half is not

It is not the origin of Aokigahara’s physical weirdness. That is ninth-century lava.

It is not the origin of Fuji cave/otherworld grammar. That is medieval.

It is not the origin of modern death-romance at the forest-lake edge. That is probably 1928/1936.

It is not the final global internet-horror phase. That belongs more to the twenty-first century.

The second half of the twentieth century is the period when Aokigahara becomes **modernly operational as a suicide-place**.

That means: widely known, searchable, reported, clinically studied, policed, periodically swept, and culturally reproducible.

24. Decade-by-decade compression

1950s: prepared landscape. Scenic/tourist/natural forest; reachable, known, but not yet fully overcoded. Matsumoto begins the decisive literary operation in 1959.

1960s: image formation. Nami no Tō and the 1960 film create the absorbed-woman-in-black-forest image; 1966 destroys the Saiko/Neba village world, adding local collective trauma and displacement.

1970s: media/search consolidation. Annual searches begin around 1970; 1974 and 1978 press nodes explicitly attach bodies, Matsumoto and “魔の樹海”; local burden becomes publicly legible.

1980s: clinical/institutional revelation. Takahashi’s 1986 paper shows that the forest’s psychology is not theatrical death but self-disappearance/quiet death; crisis response is police-heavy and psychiatrically thin.

1990s: subculture/manual/late-Heisei intensification. Tsurumi’s 1993 book and 1994 response volume mark a shift into controversial suicide-information culture; reported search counts rise; the forest approaches internet-era dark tourism and environmental clean-up politics.

25. The deepest psychological answer

The second half of the twentieth century turns Aokigahara into the place where **private disappearance becomes public machinery**.

A person goes there, in the strongest version of the wish, not to communicate but to stop being socially visible. Yet the forest increasingly surrounds that wish with mechanisms of visibility:

Matsumoto's prose;
cinema;
newspapers;
annual searches;
police files;
clinical articles;
local complaints;
manuals;
body counts;
explorer lore;
environmental clean-ups.

That is the fundamental contradiction.

Aokigahara promises disappearance, but the second half of the twentieth century makes disappearance obsessively visible.

Final thesis: 1950–1999 only

From **1950 to 1999**, Aokigahara becomes the modern suicide forest, but not in one step.

The 1950s leave a scenic, reachable, postwar landscape ready for narrative capture. Nami no Tō in 1959–60 supplies the portable image of the body-swallowing forest. The 1960 film turns that image into visual absorption. The 1966 Saiko/Neba disaster adds a local history of collective disappearance and relocation beside the forest. The 1970s make the reputation operational through annual searches and newspaper reinforcement, especially the 1974 Mainichi and 1978 Asahi nodes tying real deaths to Matsumoto and naming the local burden. The 1980s give the deepest hard evidence: Takahashi's police-based study finds a desire for self-disappearance and quiet death, with weak psychiatric intervention. The 1990s shift the forest into late-Heisei crisis culture: manual controversy, rising body-count consciousness, pre-internet exploration, environmental degradation, and the threshold of online myth.

The precise formulation is:

The second half of the twentieth century secularises Aokigahara's old threshold power into a modern apparatus of self-erasure. Matsumoto gives the image, the 1970s press gives the feedback loop, Takahashi gives the clinical key, and the 1990s give the subcultural/media acceleration. By 1999, Aokigahara is no longer merely a forest where some people die; it is a nationally legible machine for imagining disappearance.

SECTION 3

21st century (2000-2026)

Answer text reproduced below.

21st century (2000-2026)

Images:

![Aokigahara Forest | Travel Japan - Japan National Tourism Organization ...](https://tse2.mm.bing.net/th/id/OIP.XSL74OdZPMjonryKFhktQHaEq?pid=Api)

The **21st-century Aokigahara** is not simply “the suicide forest after the internet”. It is more specific and stranger than that.

From **2000 to 2026**, Aokigahara becomes a three-way conflict between:

the forest as fatal reputation;

the forest as living natural/cultural heritage;

the forest as content.

That is the century’s real structure. The twentieth century made Aokigahara nationally legible as a place of quiet self-erasure. The twenty-first century makes that legibility unstable: local authorities try to starve the suicide image, debt counsellors and patrol workers intercept people at the threshold, environmental researchers measure visitor perception, foreign films and YouTubers turn the forest into global death-content, and by the 2020s drones with thermal cameras and speakers literally search the night forest for people who may be trying to disappear. The old fantasy was “enter and vanish”. The 21st-century counter-fantasy is “enter and be found”.

I will avoid tactical detail about methods, off-trail locations, or anything that would make the forest easier to misuse. That does not weaken the analysis; the serious sources are not the lurid ones.

1. 2000–2004: the century opens with Aokigahara already numerically notorious

By the start of the 21st century, Aokigahara is no longer merely a literary/media image. It is already a recurring operational site: searched, counted, reported, visited, feared, and periodically rediscovered by journalists. A 2009 Japanese-language report says organised autumn search activity had been conducted for more than 30 years, beginning around 1970, and gives a rough trend: early searches found around 20 bodies, while the numbers later rose, including 57 in 1994, more than 70 in 1999, and 78 in 2002. This is a secondary source rather than the final police archive, so I would use it cautiously; but it captures the early-2000s public picture: Aokigahara had become a body-count forest in media consciousness. (japanese.china.org.cn)

The psychological significance is brutal. A site chosen for disappearance becomes publicly organised around recurrence: annual searches, figures, articles, and stories. By 2000,

Aokigahara has already become a **statistical place**, not just a symbolic one. The forest's old promise — “you may not be found” — is being inverted by the search ritual: the state and media periodically enter to find, count, and narrate.

2. Early 2000s: the field-guide/subculture phase begins to thicken

The early 21st century also produces a different kind of Aokigahara text: not official, not clinical, not literary, but field/subculture material. NDL lists 栗原亨's 『樹海の歩き方』, published in 2005, under the subject heading 青木ヶ原; it also lists later field/subculture materials in the same subject cluster. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

This matters because “how to walk the forest” is a different genre from “why people die there”. It marks Aokigahara's conversion into a field object for enthusiasts, urban explorers, occult readers, debunkers, dark tourists, and people testing rumours. That genre is ethically unstable: some of it punctures myths and restores natural history; some of it feeds voyeurism. But historically it is important because it shows the forest becoming **experiential content**: not only a place in books and newspapers, but somewhere to be entered, photographed, narrated, and consumed.

3. 2005–2006: the “scientific” and “why suicide here?” turn

NDL records 早野梓's 『青木ヶ原樹海を科学する：自殺するには根拠（ワケ）がある』, published in 2006. Even the title is revealing: by 2006, one strand of Japanese nonfiction is no longer asking whether Aokigahara has a suicide reputation; it is trying to give that reputation a “scientific” or explanatory frame. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

This is the century's first conceptual danger-zone. On one hand, the move from ghost-story to explanation is valuable: the forest must be understood through terrain, access, media, debt, psychology, and intervention. On the other hand, the phrase “there is a reason” risks naturalising the reputation, as if the forest itself logically calls people. The better reading is: **there are mechanisms, not destiny**. The mechanisms include media naming, accessibility, concealment affordance, social crisis, financial shame, and public repetition.

4. 2006–2007: Aokigahara becomes a natural-park management problem, not only a suicide problem

This is a crucial hidden seam. In 2006, Yamamoto and Hongo published work on Aokigahara users' environmental-care consciousness and the need for guides; NDL records the article with keywords including natural park, users, guide, environmental-care consciousness and ecotourism. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

In 2007, another Yamamoto/Hongo paper introduced social indicators into proper-use monitoring for Aokigahara. Its abstract says natural resources and user experience were threatened by overuse and bad manners, and that park management needed social

indicators as well as ecological ones; the study established 23 indicators across four zones. (jstage.jst.go.jp)

This matters because the official/academic environmental lens refuses to let “suicide forest” become the whole truth. In these studies, Aokigahara is a **natural park under use-pressure**: overuse, bad manners, guide need, user expectations, ecological protection, visitor satisfaction, social monitoring. That is a completely different Aokigahara from the one in horror films. It is not a cursed void. It is a managed public landscape where human behaviour must be measured and corrected.

5. 2007: the debt-sign intervention cuts through the mystique

The most sociologically sharp 21st-century source is the 2007 debt-sign intervention.

In July 2007, the national consumer-credit/sarakin victims’ network installed signs at Aokigahara’s entrances stating, in effect, that debt problems can be solved and urging people to consult first. The Akahata report says the group set up two signs with a 24-hour consultation number, after earlier signs had been removed over permission issues; it also says that between January and March, more than 20 people called from the forest after seeing the signs, and that many had been paying grey-zone interest where overpayment recovery might apply. (jcp.or.jp)

J-CAST’s 2008 account says the sign text included “借金の解決は、必ず出来ます！私も助かりました、まずは相談しましょう”, and reported that 29 lives had been saved after people saw the sign. NDL separately records 吉田豊樹’s 2007 Consumer Law News article on the same anti-suicide sign campaign. (j-cast.com)

This is one of the most important discoveries in the whole long history. It collapses the gothic explanation into something harder: **some people went to the forest because of solvable legal-financial despair**. Debt, shame, unlawful or recoverable payments, ignorance of remedies, isolation, and lack of advice could end at the forest edge. Aokigahara becomes not just a suicide symbol but the endpoint of a failed legal-information pathway.

The sign is also conceptually exact. It does not say “life is beautiful” in vague terms. It says: your problem may be legally soluble. That is a different kind of rescue: not metaphysical consolation, but **exit from a false impossibility**.

6. 2008: Aokigahara becomes a formal multi-actor prevention network

In June 2008, the Yamanashi governor publicly discussed the creation of いのちをつなぐ青木ヶ原ネットワーク会議, explicitly because Yamanashi’s high suicide rate partly reflected people from outside the prefecture coming to die there. He described a network involving the prefecture, local municipalities, taxi and shop industries, volunteers, posters, and

camera placement after a bereaved family donated cameras for prevention.
(pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is a key institutional moment. Aokigahara ceases to be a problem for “the police” alone. It becomes a **distributed gatekeeping system**. Local workers, transport providers, shops, volunteers, municipalities, prefecture, and police are all drawn into the same interpretive task: identify the person who may be entering the forest not as a tourist but as someone at risk.

This is the modern anti-Nami no Tō. In Matsumoto, a woman passes into the trees. In the 21st-century network, the whole local perimeter is trained to stop that passage.

7. 2008–2010: prevention, conservation and image-management start to fuse

The 2007 environmental symposium report, 『青木ヶ原樹海の保護と利用～望ましい姿を求めて私たちにできること～』, was published in 2008 and is indexed in Japan Search/NDL records as an Aokigahara protection-and-use report. (jpsearch.go.jp)

This matters because by the late 2000s, Aokigahara is no longer governable under one category. It has to be managed simultaneously as:

- a suicide-prevention site;
- a national-park/natural-monument landscape;
- a tourism resource;
- a conservation problem;
- a place of bad visitor behaviour;
- a reputational burden for local communities.

That is the 21st-century administrative problem: the forest is both **too famous** and **misfamous**.

8. 2010: Aokigahara is formally re-secured as natural heritage

In 2010, the official natural monument designation was expanded. Yamanashi’s cultural-property page says that in 1926 “Fuji primeval forest” was designated, but in **2010** about 816 ha of neighbouring Aokigahara was added and the name changed to 富士山原始林及び青木ヶ原樹海; the designated area became about 1,600 ha and lies within Fuji-Hakone-Izu National Park. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is a major symbolic counterweight to the death reputation. The state is not only trying to prevent suicides. It is also saying: this is a protected natural object, not a death zone. The name itself matters. “青木ヶ原樹海” is pulled into cultural-property language, not just newspaper tragedy.

That is one of the 21st century’s defining tensions: **the same name is used by horror media and by natural-monument law**.

9. 2011: visitor-image research measures the battle over meaning

Yamamoto and Akiba's 2011 paper studied visitors' images of Aokigahara and attitudes towards an environmental conservation cooperation fee. NDL records the article in Mount Fuji Research; the abstract says the study examined visitor attributes, consciousness, behaviour, images of the forest, support for a conservation-fee system, and willingness to pay. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

The PDF abstract says the study's aims were to understand visitor attributes/consciousness/behaviour, relate visitor image to support for a conservation fee, and estimate willingness to pay; it also states that beautiful landscape/scenery image supported agreement with the fee. (mfri.pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is more important than it looks. Aokigahara's image becomes measurable. "Suicide forest" is no longer just discourse; it is one variable among others: scenery, primitive nature, fear, conservation, access, dumping, tourism. The forest is being fought over inside survey instruments.

10. 2011–2012: the prefecture starts policing representation itself

By 2012, Yamanashi was explicitly refusing filming that might encourage suicide. A Sponichi report says the prefecture, which had had Japan's highest suicide rate per population for five consecutive years, was refusing film and television shoots about suicide in Aokigahara; officials described the forest's bad image as having become established through novels and films, and said access could be restricted because over 90% of Aokigahara was prefectural land. The same article says Yamanashi had refused location permission for a planned film based on Ishihara Shintarō's Aokigahara. (sponichi.co.jp)

This is a major 21st-century turn: **representation becomes a prevention issue**. The prefecture is no longer merely managing land or people. It is managing images, plots, scripts, cameras, and the right to reproduce the forest as death-content.

That is not censorship in the simplistic sense. It is a public-health move based on the premise that attention can be part of the hazard.

11. 2012–2020: "voice-outreach" becomes a daily operational system

Diamond Online gives a useful operational summary of the 青木ヶ原ふれあい声かけ事業. It reports that, in 2020, the project involved dedicated staff patrolling daily from roughly 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. in pairs, watching visitors and approaching those judged to be at risk; when suicidal intent was confirmed, police were called for protection. It also says shops around the forest provided information when they noticed suspicious or worrying visitors. (diamond.jp)

The same Diamond piece reports that from **2012 to 2019**, staff approached 2,350 people and 525 were protected; in 2020, they approached 346 and protected 48. (diamond.jp)

This is the 21st-century system in miniature: not a passive forest, but a **human sensor network**. Staff read clothes, posture, luggage, direction, timing, affect, and context. Shops read customers. Bus and taxi workers read passengers. Police become the next node. The old forest of unfindability is surrounded by people whose job is to notice.

12. The Ministry source shows the micro-ethnography of intervention

A Ministry-linked suicide-prevention document gives striking operational detail for the 2011 voice-outreach project: 58 people were approached that year, 28 were protected, and 39 reports were made; targets were often seen in April–May, July–August and November–December; the document notes that approaches were especially common for people arriving by bus after 17:00, and that a bus company assigned a driver familiar with the activity who could signal to monitors when a passenger seemed at risk. (mhlw.go.jp)

This is not just administration. It is a deep cultural reversal. The person who travels to disappear becomes readable at the level of bus arrival, time of day, luggage, demeanour, and driver intuition. The forest's edge becomes a **semiotic checkpoint**.

This is where the 21st century becomes almost cybernetic even before drones: the transport system itself becomes part of suicide prevention.

13. 2014: the survivor letter reveals the emotional hinge

The Yamanashi response manual includes a 2014 letter from a woman in her twenties from outside the prefecture who was approached in the forest by the voice-outreach project. The excerpt says she had gone there intending to end everything because of school, the future and her father's words; she was walking while thinking about what her life had been when staff spoke to her. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is one of the most direct 21st-century human documents. It shows the forest not as gothic myth but as a decision-threshold. The person is not just “suicidal” in the abstract. She is in a narrow cognitive tunnel: school, future, family words, the idea of ending everything. The intervention is not theoretical. It is a voice at exactly the moment the forest is about to complete its symbolic function.

The deep meaning is: **Aokigahara is where a life-narrative is almost cut, then sometimes reattached.**

14. 2015–2018: the hospital-aftercare layer appears

The Red Cross source 「青木ヶ原樹海での自殺企図者に対する退院支援」 is a 2019 technical/report item by Hatsukano Miho and others in Japanese Red Cross Medical Journal. NDL

lists its subjects as Aokigahara Jukai, suicide attempt, and discharge support; the Red Cross repository gives the same metadata. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

This is one of the most important sideways sources. It shows what happens when the forest does **not** complete the disappearance. The person becomes an emergency transport, a hospital case, a social-work problem, and a discharge-planning problem.

That is a key 21st-century expansion: Aokigahara is not just a death site. It is part of an aftercare chain. Rescue is not the end. It creates another question: where does the person go, who holds them, what psychiatric support exists, and what happens after discharge?

15. 2015–2016: global cinema turns the forest into foreign metaphor

Gus Van Sant's **The Sea of Trees** premiered at Cannes in 2015. The Cannes synopsis describes Aokigahara as a dense forest at Mount Fuji's foothills, known as a place where people contemplate life and death; the plot has an American man entering the forest intending to die, encountering a Japanese man, and moving towards survival and reconnection. (festival-cannes.com)

In 2016, the American horror film **The Forest** used Aokigahara as its setting. The Guardian review explicitly criticised it as a trashy horror film that did not know what to do with Japanese culture, noting the film's use of Aokigahara's suicide reputation as horror material. (theguardian.com)

These two films show the split in global appropriation. The Sea of Trees turns Aokigahara into grief-spirituality; The Forest turns it into horror machinery. Both are foreign metabolising systems. In neither case is the local forest allowed simply to be itself. It becomes an international screen for Western anxieties: grief, existential crisis, exotic spirituality, bad horror, haunted Japan.

This is not a minor media layer. It globalises the forest's death image beyond Japanese literary history.

16. 2017–2018: Logan Paul makes Aokigahara into platform trauma-content

The Logan Paul incident is the 21st century's single most notorious global media event involving Aokigahara. TechCrunch reported that Paul, then a major YouTuber with more than 15 million subscribers, uploaded a video from Aokigahara showing an apparent suicide victim; it had more than 1 million views before removal within 24 hours. The Guardian later reported YouTube sanctions and the platform's apology for its delayed response. (techcrunch.com)

Yamanashi's governor addressed the issue in January 2018, saying it was deeply regrettable and connecting it to the prefecture's long-running concern about the forest's negative image and image-improvement efforts. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is the moment Aokigahara becomes a global case study in **platform ethics**. The issue is no longer only Werther effect, local reputation, or Japanese suicide prevention. It becomes: what happens when a creator converts an actual death into monetisable spectacle for millions of young viewers?

The historical significance is stark. The twentieth-century press reported bodies; the twenty-first-century influencer films one. That is not just a technological difference. It is an ethical collapse from mediated public concern into direct content extraction.

17. 2018: Murata Ramu consolidates the field-reportage counter-archive

NDL records 村田らむ's 『樹海考』, published in 2018, as a book on Aokigahara's formation, historical background, ruins, objects, faith and "truth", based on more than 100 visits; author notes describe Murata as a field reporter who has covered Aokigahara for roughly 20 years. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

This is not academic history, but it is serious evidence for the modern "jukai imaginary". Murata's significance is that he sits at the border between reportage, subculture, debunking, urban exploration, and taboo. He records the forest as material culture: ruins, objects, rumours, faith, routes, lies, and the dark-tourism afterlife.

Handled carefully, this material is essential. It shows what official sources cannot: how people actually imagine, enter, talk about, exaggerate, and test the forest.

18. 2019: the forest is now simultaneously prevention site and cultural-property object

By the end of the 2010s, Aokigahara's two official identities sit side by side. It is a natural monument/national-park landscape, after the 2010 expansion of the protected area; it is also a suicide-prevention patrol zone with voice-outreach, transport observation, and police linkage. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

This duality is essential. The local-state answer is not "close the forest". It is "change its image, protect life, protect nature, and restore legitimate forms of visitation." That is harder than simply restricting access. The forest must be both entered and not mis-entered; seen but not sensationalised; visited but not exploited.

19. 2020: the pandemic-era threshold is not yet fully mapped

For 2020 specifically, the strongest concrete Aokigahara figure in the sources I have here is operational: Diamond reports that in 2020, the two municipalities approached 346 people and protected 48 through the voice-outreach work. (diamond.jp)

I would not overclaim a pandemic-specific Aokigahara transformation without more local records. It is tempting to talk broadly about COVID isolation, mental health and suicide, but unless tied to Aokigahara-specific sources, that becomes generic padding. What we can say is narrower: by 2020, the patrol/outreach apparatus is functioning as a routine, quantified intervention system.

20. 2020s: the “image change” strategy becomes explicit doctrine

Yamanashi’s 2024 governor’s press conference is one of the clearest modern statements of the official counter-myth. Asked about Aokigahara suicides, the governor said the forest did not originally have this image and called Nami no Tō a troublesome work in that respect; he said traditional “water’s edge” intervention would continue, but that changing the image is the fundamental countermeasure. He described Aokigahara as originally a “source of life” and a forest full of the shine of life, and said tourists should experience its true attraction. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

This is extraordinary because it states the official theory plainly:

the death image is part of the problem; re-imaging the forest is part of prevention.

The governor also linked image-change with reviving/using old Fuji routes, including the Shōjiguchi route through the Aokigahara area towards Fuji. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

That is historically sophisticated, whether or not one agrees with every policy implication. It tries to reverse the twentieth-century anti-pilgrimage. Instead of road → forest → disappearance, the preferred image becomes road/trail → forest → Fuji → wonder, nature, ascent, return.

21. 2024: the drone phase begins

In September 2024, Yamanashi began using drones for night patrols around Aokigahara. TV Asahi reported that thermal-camera drones would search for people from above, and if someone was found, a speaker-equipped drone would carry a ground monitor’s voice to them. The prefecture’s health-promotion official said daytime patrols were already conducted 365 days a year and that drones would prioritise night-time gaps. (news.tv-asahi.co.jp)

JDRONE’s press release gives the technical-operational frame: from September 2024, it would conduct drone-based patrol and voice-outreach work in the Aokigahara area of Fujikawaguchiko and Narusawa, using thermal-camera-equipped DJI drones capable of detecting people at night. (kyodonewsprwire.jp)

This is the 21st century's conceptual climax. The forest famous for making people unfindable is now watched by thermal imaging and airborne voice. The state does not merely enter the forest; it looks down through the canopy with machine vision.

That is not just “new technology”. It is symbolic reversal:

old Aokigahara: the forest absorbs you;

new Aokigahara: your heat signature can call a voice from the sky.

22. 2025: the drone programme becomes public-facing image work

Yamanashi's 2025 public-relations page presented a programme titled “ドローンがいのちと樹海を守る!?” , saying that because many suicides are confirmed in Aokigahara, the prefecture began night-time drone patrols the previous fiscal year; the programme also promised to introduce both drone activity and the forest's “original charm”. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

That pairing is crucial: **life-saving technology + forest charm**. Even drone surveillance is folded into image rehabilitation. The public message is not simply “we patrol a suicide site”. It is “we protect life and protect the forest's true nature.”

This is the 2020s settlement: prevention and rebranding are not separate policies. They are one policy.

23. 2026: Aokigahara remains a global online symbol, but the local state keeps trying to pull it back

As of the present decade, Aokigahara remains globally recognisable through films, influencer scandals, horror discussion, Reddit threads, travel blogs, and sensationalised articles. The Reddit Japanese-language thread 「森という異世界」 is particularly valuable as vernacular evidence: the poster contrasts foreign horror depictions of physically aggressive ghosts with a Japanese-feeling image of Aokigahara as a place for “painful, sad, lonely people” going to their end, and a forest that envelops unsupported souls with sacredness and awe. ([reddit.com](https://www.reddit.com))

That is not an official fact-source. It is a discourse clue. It shows the continuing split between foreign horror consumption and Japanese affective seriousness. In foreign content, Aokigahara is often an exotic haunted forest. In this Japanese vernacular register, it is sadder, quieter, more sacred, and more morally delicate.

That distinction may be the most important cultural point of the 21st century. The same global keyword — “Aokigahara” — now carries very different emotional grammars depending on who uses it.

24. The 21st-century Aokigahara has six competing identities

By 2026, Aokigahara is not one thing. It is at least six.

First, **the suicide-prevention forest**: daily patrols, voice outreach, shops, transport staff, police, protected persons, discharge support, and drones. (diamond.jp)

Second, **the rebranded life-forest**: a protected natural monument, a “source of life”, a place of beauty, old routes, caves, national park use and image change. (pref.yamanashi.jp)

Third, **the conservation-management forest**: visitor expectations, bad manners, guide need, social indicators, fee-support, proper use and environmental care. (jstage.jst.go.jp)

Fourth, **the debt/legal-rescue forest**: the place where consumer-debt despair can be interrupted by legal advice and the assertion that debt problems may be solvable. (jcp.or.jp)

Fifth, **the global-content forest**: Hollywood films, YouTube scandal, dark tourism, foreign horror, platform ethics and influencer disrespect. (festival-cannes.com)

Sixth, **the field/vernacular forest**: Murata’s repeated visits, old blogs, forums, Reddit, urban legends, secret-village myths, corpse-tourism disgust, local rumours and debunking. (ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp)

The mistake is to call all six “the suicide forest” and stop there. The 21st century is defined by their collision.

25. The deepest 21st-century psychological transformation

The twentieth-century clinical key was Takahashi’s “self-disappearance / quiet death” finding from the 1980s. The 21st century does not replace that; it surrounds it with detection.

A person may go to Aokigahara wanting silence, unfindability, and exit from the social ledger. But in the 21st century, the forest is wrapped in systems that make that wish visible:

the bus driver notices;
the shopkeeper notices;
the patrol worker notices;
the police respond;
the hospital receives;
the social worker plans discharge;
the debt counsellor reframes the problem;
the governor reframes the forest;
the drone detects heat;
the internet converts it into discourse.

That is the central contradiction:

Aokigahara is where the wish not to be seen becomes intensely watched.

26. The 21st century's strongest thesis

The 21st century does not merely continue Aokigahara's suicide reputation. It transforms that reputation into a managed, contested, global system.

The early 2000s inherit the body-count/search forest. The mid-2000s produce field guides, "scientific" explanation, environmental-management studies and the crucial debt-sign intervention. In 2008, Yamanashi formalises a multi-actor network to intercept people at the threshold. In 2010–2012, the forest is reframed as natural heritage and representation itself becomes a public-health problem. In the 2010s, visitor-image research, daily outreach, survivor letters, Red Cross discharge support, foreign films and the Logan Paul scandal turn the forest into both a care-system object and a global media wound. In the 2020s, the official doctrine becomes explicit: change the image, restore the life-forest, continue intervention, and use drones to cover the night.

The exact formulation is:

The 21st-century Aokigahara is no longer just a place where people disappear. It is a place where disappearance is contested by law, medicine, debt counselling, conservation, tourism, platform ethics, local pride, official rebranding and machine vision. The forest's tragic reputation persists, but the century's defining movement is counter-disappearance: finding, speaking, protecting, re-narrating and returning the forest to life.